

Vertigo



Photo: Club climb of Te Heu Heu (photo by Simon Williamson)

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club - Wellington Section

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Section News

Section Nights

At the November section night Erik Bradshaw came along to talk about "Skiing the long white cloud – a journey the length of the Southern Alps". Erik brought along some great props and had some brilliant photos and stories to share of his ski traverse of the length of the Southern Alps in 2011. All who attended seemed to enjoy Erik's talk and his custom made ski gear was closely inspected by many. The evening was certainly an inspiration to many.

In December we are having another movie night (and will also hold our AGM). The AGM will be short and sweet so we can get into the movie watching part of the evening.

The first section night in the new year will be in February. There will be a Vertigo sent out towards the end of January so please send through any cool photos or trip reports to Carolyn at kaz1963@gmail.com. If you can't be bothered with a full trip report a short summary of where you've been, what you've done, with who along with a picture would be great.

Section Library sortout

Huge thanks to those that came along for the first round of the section library sort out. Some order was made of the mayhem and pizzas consumed happily. We're now in the process of updating our database and will plan another session in the new year to check books off against the database. The toughest part of the evening was not being able to find a corner to read some of the cool books we have. Once we have the library all sorted we will have a process in place for people to see what books we have and be able to borrow them.

Christmas function

A family-friendly section Christmas outing is taking place on Saturday 5th December at Catchpool, Rimutaka Forest Park - <http://www.doc.govt.nz/parks-and-recreation/places-to-go/wellington-kapiti/places/rimutaka-forest-park/catchpool-and-orongorongo-valleys/>. We've decided to waive the \$5 per person previously mentioned. We'll put on some drinks and a BBQ dinner (catering for vegetarians / gluten free folk etc). We'll meet at 4:30pm and be eating around 6:45pm. You may want to go for a tramp in the park or a climb down the coast beforehand. Afterwards you have the option of camping overnight or heading for home depending on what you're in the mood for. Please register for the event (so we know how many we are catering for) by emailing us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz with names, numbers, dietary needs.

Notification of Section AGM

The AGM of the Wellington section of the NZAC will be held at the Southern Cross starting at 6pm on Wednesday 2 December 2015. All NZAC members are invited to attend. There will be no boring speeches, painful reading out of reports or pontificating going on. Our intent is to ensure the AGM is as short as possible so we can get onto the fun part of the evening – watching a selection of climbing movies guaranteed to make you want to shut your eyes and stick your fingers in your ears and go lalalalalala. There is an embargo on their release until the 2nd so we can't tell you the titles until the night. AGM reports will be circulated prior to the meeting to save time and avoid having to read them out at the meeting.

The agenda for the AGM is as follows :

- Introduction – Eric Duggan
- Voting for any contested committee positions
- Confirmation of committee for 2016
- Comments / feedback on reports

Current committee is as follows :

- Simon Williamson – Chair, Alpine course co-ordinator
- Eric Duggan – Co-Chair, Trip co-ordinator
- Mark Leslie – Treasurer
- Carolyn Ellis – Secretary
- Aviette Musin – Banffmeister and Avalanche training co-ordinator
- Mark Johnston – Committee member
- Nish Shah - Social Media Wizard (Twitter and Facebook)
- Josh Pemberton - Booking form developer
- Vincent Zintzen / Scott Taylor - Rock course co-ordinators
- Marketing and communications – vacant
- Librarian - vacant

All existing committee members have indicated they are happy to remain on the committee. Please forward any nominations for the 2016 committee positions to Carolyn at kaz1963@gmail.com prior to the AGM. If you have any questions about what being on the committee entails please ask one of the existing committee members. We're keen that people understand that being on the committee isn't an arduous task.

New website!

Have you noticed that the new NZAC website is up and running? It's been a hard slog for national office but the new site is looking pretty stunning. Wellington section has a presence on the site and we will be loading more information over time. Feedback and ideas are welcome – send them through to wellington@alpineclub.org.nz

Section Nights are at the Southern Cross, 39 Abel Smith Street, Te Aro, Wellington on the first Wednesday of each month. New and prospective members are welcome. Meetings start at 6.00 pm with some nibbles provided – koha at the door. Grab a drink from the bar.

Upcoming Trips, Courses and Events

Wellington Section Trips

Please indicate your interest in leading or participating in trips by emailing the committee at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz and the committee will then proceed with firming up details around dates, etc.

December 2 nd	Section AGM and movie evening at Southern Cross
December 5 th	Christmas camping / BBQ at Catchpool
January 4 th – 10 th	Annual climbing camp at Tukino. There will be heaps of activities going on, including lots of family friendly stuff and alpine and rock climbing for a range of abilities. Register your interest or find out more by emailing camp@alpineclub.org.nz

Trip Reports

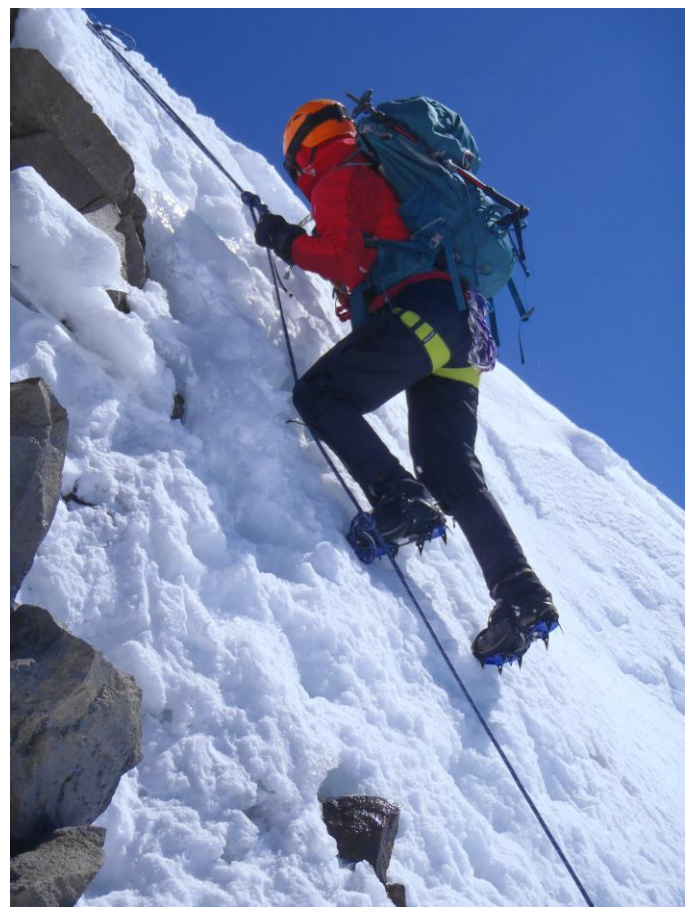
World Cup vs Summit attempt

By Frances Boyson

If looking for a way to test a fledgling mountaineer's commitment to the cause, pitting a summit attempt against a New Zealand–Australia Rugby World Cup final is a pretty good one. If there's one thing alpinists have to be good at it's problem-solving. Various strategies were mooted and enacted to get round this troubling concurrence. Josh and David didn't mention their radio when they announced their intention to camp overnight on Ruapehu's summit plateau, but we all knew what was going on. The ski tourers at the lodge were just too damn hipster to mention the game, but I feel sure they were secretly on their phones in their sleeping bags during the night. And the rest of us swore anyone with functioning internet to secrecy in an attempt to stall time and watch the recorded game on our return to the city.

Our group of 11 budding climbers had mostly undertaken Intro and Basic level alpine courses with NZAC Wellington Section during the winter. Our new crampon, ice axe and anchor skills were fresh in our minds but, in general, our confidence levels about how to plan and undertake an alpine trip more generally were a bit lower. So we were glad of the opportunity to put our skills into practice with instructors part of the group.

On the Saturday we left the lodge at 6.30am in perfect conditions to attempt Te Heuheu via the East Ridge. The ascent was mainly straightforward in such great visibility but nonetheless put a few of us out of our comfort zones. We split into two groups and took turns leading the way to save energy. We zigzagged up the hill, with wonderful views of Ngauruhoe amongst low cloud. As we climbed, the gradient steepened and the chilly wind increased. When the slope was at its steepest and most exposed, I realised that with no instructor at my side, this time it was on me to keep myself safe, have confidence in my skills, and push my way to the top. For me this was a terrifying but strengthening experience, forcing me to be confident in my crampons keeping me secure on the snow, and refining my techniques to make my footing sturdier and my movements more efficient. At the first step a rope was set up in a simple quasi-belay around a snow stake to aid those less comfortable on the ice. I enjoyed the security and confidence that the rope provided and the experience of using climbing techniques



Negotiating the first step (by David Eaton)

on ice (turns out the 'just stand up' mantra was just as useful here as on rock). I also enjoyed Simon's chortles of laughter afterwards when he recalled that the rope that had enabled these confident manoeuvres hadn't actually been attached to anything.



The "anchor" on the first step (by Paul McCredie)



Pondering the second step (by Paul McCredie)

Towards the top Jimmy nimbly hopped up the final step sans rope but, having observed his experience of the snow in the last few feet, ('scary, steep and soft with a disconcerting stomp', he recalled later) most of us instead traversed beneath incredible icicle formations instead to reach an easy walk up to the peak.



Ice (by Daan Steenkamp)

For me, this last section was the most mentally challenging part of the day: traversing the top of a slope with softish snow, tremendous exposure and rising winds. For those who went up the step this was the hardest part of their day, requiring confidence and composure to manage. But we all made it to the summit in happy spirits, even if it did take me twenty minutes to recover my ability to talk or take in my surroundings after the mental pressure of the traverse.

We had ascended 1000m which was significantly more than what we had travelled in our training weekends. I had been concentrating so hard on my steps that it felt like only an hour had passed, but by the time us tortoises made it to the top it had been five hours.



Tukino Peak (by Paul McCredie)

From the summit we walked slowly along the ridge and up to Tukino Peak, admiring the captivating ice formations and the jagged crests and lines of Ruapehu's many peaks. We dug a snow bollard for an abseil down onto the summit plateau. I took one for the team and volunteered to take the first abseil down

(to everyone's slight surprise, they revealed later). That meant that I was the first to get the bigger surprise: on reaching the bottom of the rope I discovered that I was only a quarter of the way through the descent. Being alone on the slope meant there wasn't really any space to panic about this: I had to have confidence in my down-climbing and front-pointing techniques. It lasted an age but I finally made it to the bottom and felt full to the brim with joy as I walked over to meet the rest of our party. And I blessed my stiff boots when I learnt later how



Down-climbing from abseil (by Frances Boyson)

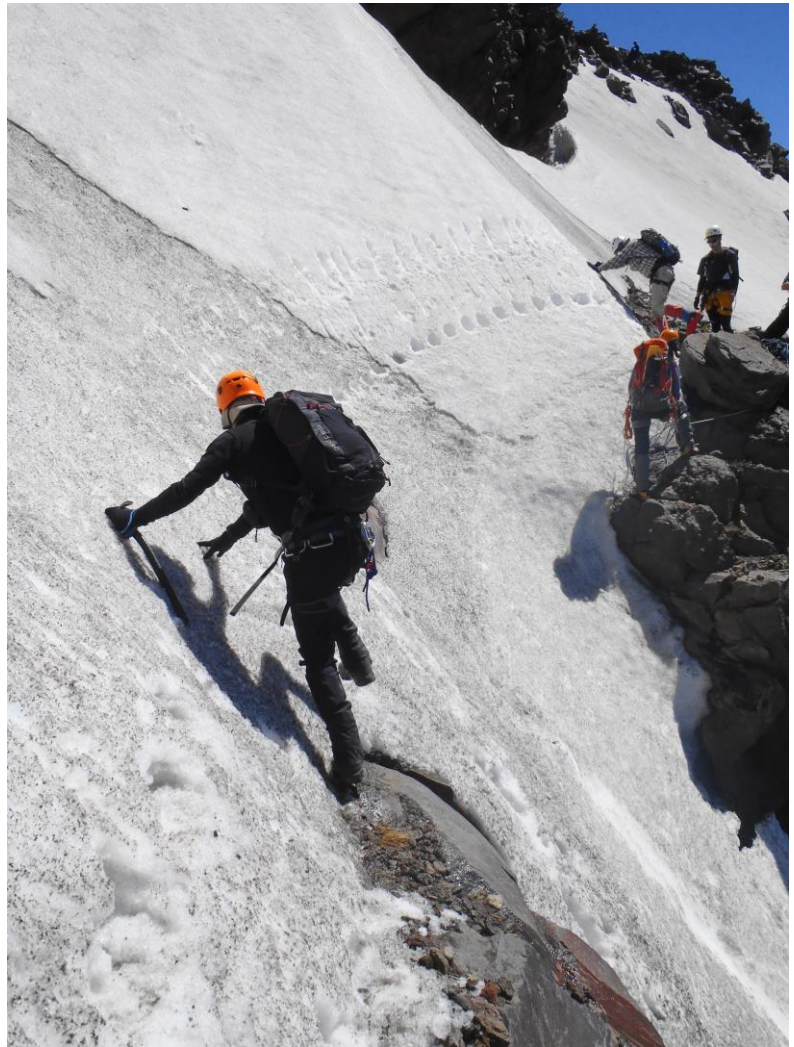
some others had struggled to get purchase in the ice with their more flexible soles.

From there a few of us detoured towards the Whangaehu Glacier to visit Whangaehu Hut whilst the others glissaded and sled their way back to the lodge in the soft afternoon snow.



Descending to Whangaehu Hut (by Frances Boyson)

Sunday's weather was even more beautiful, and we spent the morning revising our anchor skills, discussing offsetting techniques for enhancing security and debating the situations when dynamic and non-dynamic materials are best deployed. We all added 'practise knots' to our to-do list, and added prussic to our Christmas list. Then we had an exercise in problem-solving: finding the best route to get up to the top that will both get us back to the lodge in time for lunch and match the capability of the whole group. We alternated between ascending snow and scrambling up sections of rock. The less confident amongst us took advantage of eager belayers and Jimmy found out on all our behalves just how cold your back will get doing a bucket belay.



Traversing fun (by David Eaton)

We felt grateful and lucky to have had the chance to practice our skills in this safe environment. For most of us it was a stretch, and for me it was a big jump going from learning the skills to a full summit attempt. The experience of learning to trust in my technique and manage my own requirements for focus and composure in more testing situations was invaluable. We all really appreciated what the Wellington Section is doing to teach enthusiastic newcomers the skills and provide them with opportunities to develop, such as this weekend afforded. It made a big difference to have the experience of leading our own trip and making our own decisions but having Carolyn, Simon and David around to check our abseil and belay set-ups and give advice on our route, safety and technique. Thanks too to Mark and Eric for organising the weekend away.

As for the rugby, when Josh and David returned from the summit on Sunday afternoon, their beaming smiles when the final was mentioned gave the game away. But only I saw.

Spring ski touring at Tukino

By Jon Glover

While on a recent trip to Samoa, I received an email from Mac stating that those fine people from down south were holding a ski touring meet at Tukino and would I be interested in joining. Now snowy peaks and fresh lines are a far cry from white sandy beaches and razor sharp coral, but hey you can never miss out on an opportunity especially for some late season skiing.

Cutting work a bit early on Friday we arrived at Tukino to find Auckland had invaded the Wellington meet, well for ski touring at least. Jim, Jon and Mac representing the big smoke while Dave, Eric and Sarah represented Wellington. Fiona made up the 4th representative from Auckland, residing in Taupo which is obviously on the Auckland side of Tukino. Gary being from Napier gave half point to each side.

Saturday morning started abruptly with the climbers in the lodge getting off to a semi alpine start, while the skiers stayed in bed for a more humane touring get away. A brisk jaunt up the Whangehu Glacier popped us out just below the Crater Lake and a short skin to the summit plateau provided a spot for lunch. Eric through no word and only actions had demonstrated that he was a beast in the fitness department having reached the top of the glacier and then skiing half way down and skinned up again before the "young" folk at the back reached the top.

After a chilly lunch David punished his body by following Eric down the Whakapapa side, the skiing being so good they went all the way to the bottom of the Fast West T. The younger folk in the group started down the Mangatoetoenui Glacier enjoying wide turns in perfect spring skiing conditions. The sun was out and hardly a cloud in the sky. A break half way down led to an hour's rest perched on a warm rock shooting the breeze.

A lovely afternoon was spent in the hut, with a few of the younger folk getting a bashing from the old guard. Eric's team nacho extravaganza was enjoyed by all and made sure there was enough energy around to get up the hill again in the morning.

Another perfect day dawned and this time the skiers were out of the hut before the climbers....just. A quick skin directly up the Mangatoetoenui Glacier found us enjoying more great skiing conditions with everyone back at the hut in plenty of time to get back to the respective destinations at a reasonable hour.

Thanks to all those who organised, looking forward to seeing everyone on the hill again.

From Manakau to Te Ao Whekere, Taking up the Pen

April 4-6 2015

Lorraine Johns



"Not all who wander are lost", Mount Earnslaw Massif, April 2015

It's the second day of Easter. The sun is shining and in the air is the cheerful bustle of families and friends on holiday together. It's late in the day and I'm wandering along a river. I can hear the wind stirring, but it touches me only lightly in the sheltered gorge. I know these waters well - the Hapuku River in the Seaward Kaikouras. I might have been tempted to call this river an old friend, if it wasn't for the greasiness of the rock that paves the way ahead.

It has taken me all day to get here and now I rarely even cross the river, hastily bouldering over obstacles. For the price of a precarious moment or two, this is a fast way to travel and I arrive at my bivvy site below Stace Saddle in less than three hours, just on dark.

On this particular trip I'm revisiting memories. I'd set off from Christchurch the previous day to immerse myself in the Lewis tops. It was one of those days where hunters and deer materialise in and out of mist, fortunately not at the same time. Where the dewy veil draws back abruptly to allow a clear view from the summit, but the bushline is regained as the gales are picking up and fog is reclaiming the tops. I had traced out a circuit over Mount Technical (cellphone reception on the peak allowing me to take a call from my little goddaughter Amelie), nipping across to Brass Monkey Bivouac, before retreating to the security of a cosy bed.



On Mount Technical

Tonight I've left all homeliness behind, but I'm not alone. For a start there are the Christchurch Tramping Club boys who have returned from an attempt on Manakau, being driven back from the summit ridge by a rising and powerful wind. Then there is the little possum that refuses to budge until I half-heartedly throw something at it, deliberately missing. And then there is the big possum, and this time I possibly only miss because my aim is poor. The sky is clear and the moon full, so it's tempting to keep on walking. But there is an unlimited supply of water at my bedside, so I settle in on the banks of the creek. I pack everything away from prying eyes, except my empty billy, which I balance on my cooker ready for the next morning.

I settle into my bivvy bag. Just one more thing now. I rummage around my first aid kit, but cannot find the sleeping tablet I'd carefully packed. I stare at my empty hand and the night darkens as anxiety washes over me. In the course of an evening eight weeks ago, my life changed forever. I silently whisper words from a list of French vocabulary over again, but there is only one thing on my mind. I close my eyes and the blackness swirls around me.

All of a sudden, a clanging sound rings in one ear, piercing my half-slumber. I shriek as my empty billy topples off my cooker and I open my eyes to see the little possum scuttling away. I glance nervously at the boys, but no-one stirs. The immortal part of myself apparently intact, I close my eyes. My billy chimes again. This time it is the large possum. I do not squeal, but as it slinks away, my parting thoughts are decidedly unfriendly. I take the billy off the cooker, but as night draws to a close, I'm pretty sure I didn't dream those paws touching my legs ...

When my alarm rings I wake to find water seeping into the narrow opening of my bivvy bag. I zip it up, entombing myself. When my alarm next wakes me, it's still raining lightly, but it's definitely time to start moving. Breakfast is a subdued affair as I stand gazing upon the route ahead, as it disappears into thick mist. The boys come over to introduce themselves, and I tell them I'm going to go through with my plan, because my car's on the other side. They offer me a lift, but I've fallen too far into a heuristic trap. "It might clear" their leader cheerfully offers, unconvincingly, as I step into the gloom.

I stop for nothing and soon find myself heading along the ridge from Stace Saddle. I can see little except for the muted colours of the scrub at my feet and the faint outline of dark jutting rock just ahead, as the trail winds upward. There is a gentle breeze and the rain is light, but the tussock is saturated and the air feels cold. Ah I'm soaked and my gloveless fingers are pretty numb, but the moisture on my face cannot be fully attributed to the elements. My mood suffers, I'm suffering. All the more reason to be here. So I switch my iPod on and play the saddest song that I know. On repeat. For the next hour or so the most notable occurrence involves passing a lone, but very large, slug. With grim satisfaction I resolve to bypass all peaks and just keep on walking until I'm off the ridge and back at the car.

Then, suddenly, everything begins to change. A rainbow materialises in the mist, stretching out from my feet through the narrow rock corridors into dissipating cloud. I know what is going to happen next. As I gain the broad ridge, I burst out of the grey and into the blue. It is clearer than crystal, the landscape painted with a palette so vibrant as to confound the senses. And there is my mountain, its distinctive banding softly beckoning. The air is still and I give myself over to the gentle warmth of the autumn sun. I take everything out, everything off. Nothing feels more pressing right now than being warm and dry. There's cellphone reception up here so I reach out to my friends. Ellie and Gina are attending weddings. Fiona is riding around a farm. Colin likes the look of my mountain and tells me that he knows why I am here. Nank is asked to work out where here is (too easy!).

It's not entirely possible to relax right now, so after a while I put some damp clothes back on (don't want to scandalise the alpine slugs) and head up the hill. The rock is starting to radiate heat by the time I near the culmination of Surveyor Spur. I stash my overnight gear safely away, to give my body a break while I tackle the summit ridge. I think that it is a strange reality to be in such a beautiful place when I am so sad. But there is no place in the world that feels better to me right now. I continue walking carefully along the ridge and look around me.

I appreciate the shifting colours, the way my horizon keeps changing with every step higher, and that I'm going to be able to see everything from the summit. The Totaranuni farmer Kevin later tells me about his late buddy who took on the difficult challenge of ascending the face of Manakau in winter, with more than one cold night spent sleeping out on the route. With a leg on each side of the ridge I can say it's like being in two different worlds, especially as the sun is arcing through the sky, casting a lengthening shadow over the steep face to my left, while the gently-sloping flanks to my right bask in its glow.

And just like that I find myself on the summit of Manakau, the casual splendour of the Seaward Kaikouras laid bare. An old memory wells up, a longing to traverse this ridgeline in its entirety. There is a large remnant block of snow on the north side of the summit, and I smile because a gem of a plan for next summer is forming. But for now, it's time to follow a different path. Though not before I stash some marshmallow Easter eggs in the summit cairn ... and send another "guess where" picture to Nank.

When I arrive back at my gear it is getting on in the afternoon, but there's something very reassuring about carrying my home on my back. I take a bit of time to melt snow and think that I may as well prepare dinner. One specially dehydrated for the trip Rob and I had planned in the first week of

February, a trip for which I had spent the summer training and with which I was completely preoccupied as the clock was ticking away. I am thinking a lot and I try to brush my thoughts aside, but I have to think about something. So I think that even though it's a little early for dinner and I'd been planning on carrying mine while it rehydrated, I might as well consume it now. Shortly, I rise and continue along the ridge. But, you know, there is a tall and lean fella bounding nimbly just ahead of me. He isn't looking my way but I can almost see that infectious grin, his light tread carrying him beyond my reach. I've been following in those steps all day, as I've done so many times before, the precious imprint of my special person.

There is a crescent moon tonight. As I write I can see it shining over The Beehive. The city lights flicker as families reunite for their evening meal. We are all under the same moon, silhouetted against the deepening blue-black sky, as dusk quietly yields to the still autumn night. I look upon the vast emptiness of the cloudless horizon, yearning for a world that can never be.



Guess where

Time passes and I find myself drawing water from an icy river, near glaciated headwaters. The pale winter moon is waxing. I see fire glowing in the windowpanes of the nearby hut and can feel the warmth of the merry voices within. The clumsy movements of my numb fingers delay me from returning. I am alone and whisper, *where are you*.



The endless horizon of the Serengeti, August 2014

Night begins to fall as I walk along the particular ridge in this particular story. Something unearthly is rising up above the thick cloud that extends from the sprawling roots of the mountain out to the sea. It's a blood moon! It looks more like a mushroom. But it's still really nice. I'm a little tired, my stamina is lacking and I'm getting cold as I head downhill. I don my down jacket and decide I'm not going to climb anything else today. But when I start re-ascending, my spirits rise in step with my body temperature. I soon arrive at a little campsite, on a flat spot near the toe of Te Ao Whekere's summit ridge. I tell myself I'll set up then go climb my peak. But as soon as my bed is made, I jump into it.

Perhaps you were expecting me to show a little more resolve? Ah but I'm blissfully warm in my winter sleeping bag, with both a thermarest and snowfoam to cushion my sleep. I am also cocooned in my sturdy bivvy bag. And I have some delicious food which I resolve to eat immediately.

I know this must contrast starkly with the experience that same young man, Simon, had here under a full moon, one wintry spring. I imagine it all through his eyes, wondering if he slept in this same

spot - if sleep is what you can call it when you shiver through the night with little more than the satisfaction of travelling light and fast between you and the freezing air. Simon would tell me all about his experiences with great delight, making me laugh, the conversation often starting with a message from the summit like it did on his own journey here.



Simon

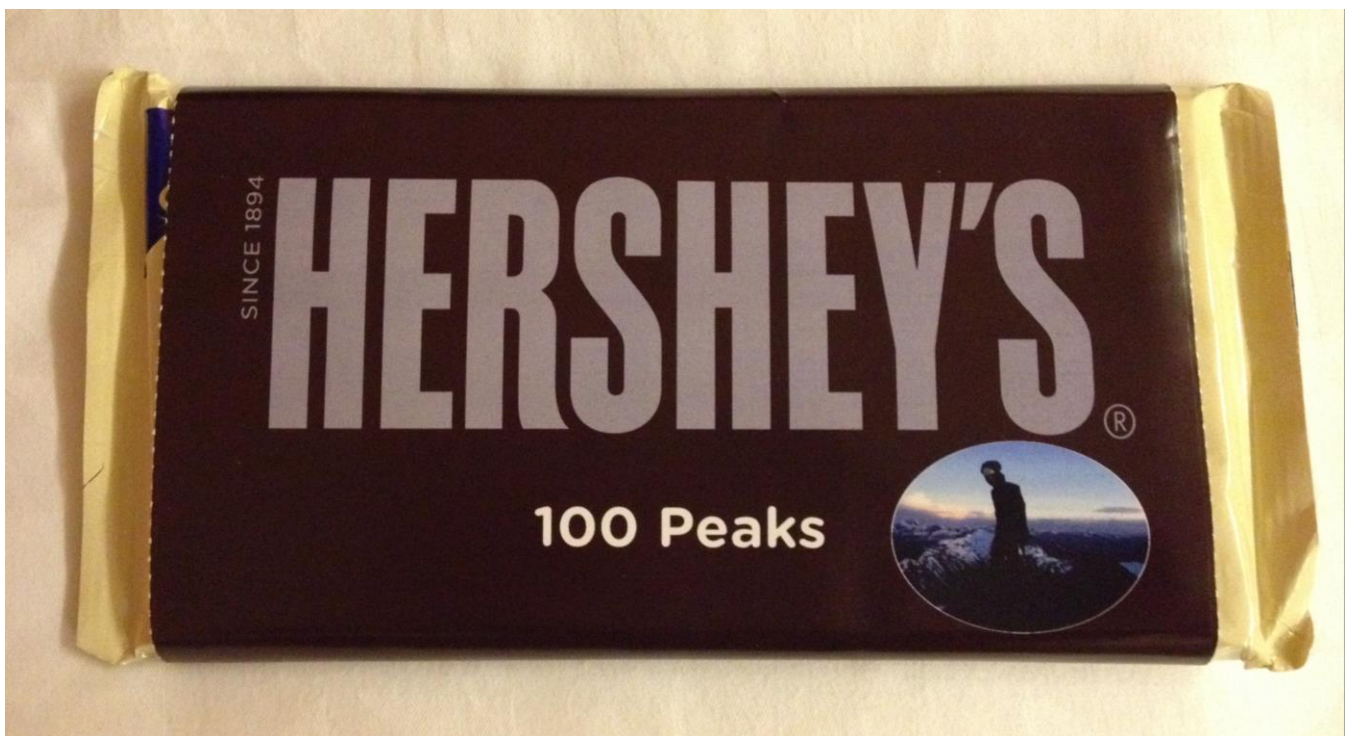
Simon would surely sigh if he knew that I was lying here reading recipes from a magazine stashed away in my pack, having travelled neither light nor fast today. But it is not a bad thing to be so well set up so far above sea level, on a rocky alpine plateau lit up by the full moon. And when I turn the page it reveals recipes dreamed up by my favourite chef! I'm even snacking on one of his creations! I write to Mr Jeremy Dixon later and tell him a little about this moment. When he replies he sounds delighted and even forgives me for the Whittaker's milk chocolate that I have 'fessed up to eating earlier in the day. Maybe calories weigh less at altitude?

It's a bewitching place to go to sleep, and even after I do succumb, my rest is disturbed at least once, providing an opportunity to take it all in again. The moon is shining very brightly and I think that I could get up and ascend Te Ao Whekere, but promptly fall back to sleep. When I finally wake, I lie on my back a while, watching the sun rise over the Kaikoura Peninsula, the sky tinged a soft pink. The many years I spent learning from Simon have provided me with what I need to navigate these mountains. But even more so, my eyes are opened to experiencing the wonder around me in every possible way.

Summitting the peak is quite uneventful, except for the business of the summit shot. I've been taking selfies on each of my mountains, something the photogenic Simon would usually do. Right now, no matter what angle I try, my eyes are so puffy I look like a baby frog.

The descent is pretty straightforward. Or at least would have been if I'd possessed more than 300 millilitres of water without also being cursed with whale-like consumption tendencies. I split the descent into three sections distinguished by rapidly depleting sips of water, and then a fourth section of pure thirst. I see lots of scree, I see more goats. The magic has gone, I run out of water, so of course I take the long way down into the embrace of the matagouri lurking below. I reach the road late morning and go crazy drinking from a stream that is clearly a hangout for the local bovines.

When I arrive back at Kevin and Sandy's farm, they kindly invite me in for some refreshments and a chat. Their orphan deer Lucky has been looking after Ellie's car during my absence, having clearly been struck by Cupid's arrow. I am slightly relieved to find neither hybrid offspring nor empty wrappers where my chocolate supply is secreted away. I then eat that chocolate all the way to Christchurch, only pausing twice (for more chocolate in Kaikoura, and to destroy some of the evidence before I pick Ryan and Ellie up from Christchurch Airport).



The best chocolate in the world, August 2014

I ask a trusted friend what she thinks of all this. She worries. She reminds me of certain comments. That is, observations from those who felt I needed to get more perspective on what has happened to me. In one breath they might speak of their affection and respect for my lost love, then in the next tell me what I need to do so I can see my situation as less severe. After all, we'd been shortly separated. But grief is personal, and it is not a problem to be repaired or an illness to be healed. I once read that when someone else tries to fix, rationalise, or deny the pain that accompanies grief, this only deepens the bereaved person's terror. But if you haven't

experienced grief, there are no words to convey its horror. I tell my friend that I wish nobody would ever have cause to understand what this is like.

I tell her a number of things actually.

I tell her I wish to have my voice. That I am stronger, sometimes.

I tell her I feel very humble that many people reached out in sympathy and with kindness, including those who were also grieving their friend, and those who didn't even know me at all. And I'm so grateful to those who took me in when I was unable to sleep with the door closed, because I didn't want to be shut away in darkness.

But above all, I tell my friend that I need to write about my experiences because there was a time when all I could do was read such accounts, difficult though they were to find, those of the person who loved and lost a climber.

And finally I tell her there is one more reason.

I still wander alone in the dark. I can see the stars above me, but day hasn't dawned. There isn't a moment, waking or not, where I am not conscious of what has been lost. The smallest of thoughts can linger, awaiting a cure that does not exist. I think of the joy Simon took in writing about his adventures and how happy I was to be asked first to read about them. I want very much to read about them one more time. Always one more time. So here I am, taking up the pen.



Best friends

Tapuae-o-Uenuku

Paul McCredie and David Kepes

A distant snow covered monolith rising majestically from the ocean - on a crisp winter's day, it's a sight Wellingtonians know well. At 2885m, the highest peak outside of the Southern Alps, it was Ed's first conquest and subsequently the climb has become something of a rite of passage in the tramper-to-climber metamorphose. As a rookie snow craft graduate, it is a most tantalising sight.

Unfortunately, the Inland Kaikoura mountains are not the easiest place to get to. So when my fellow fifty-something mate from Blenheim suggests a climb of Tapuae-o-Uenuku I can't get my crampons on quick enough. Studying weather maps, I'm pestering David every couple of days with potential windows of opportunity - he won't have a guilt free weekend until we've knocked the bugger off....

Finally, in early November, after much hand wringing about the rapidly dwindling snow cap, we're away from the Hodder Bridge in the Awatere Valley, remotest Marlborough. The six to eight hour slog up the Hodder River to the base of Tappie is legendary. Anywhere between 60 to 90 river crossings are necessary. And by river crossings, I mean fording a fast flowing torrent trapped between narrow rock walls as the river falls 1000m in 15 km. This is no lazy Canterbury braided river system and definitely not a place to be if it starts raining.

The water is ice cold but I've taken the advice to wear 3mm neoprene socks inside my boots. They work a charm, my feet remain toasty while David's are numb in half an hour. It's a beautiful walk - in a barren, haunting kind of way. Interrupted only by the occasional family of goats and a solitary Chamois who performs a captivating display of boulder hopping.

About three quarters of the way in we meet an impassible canyon but there's a track which takes evasive action via a punishing sidle. Back down to the river, the hut is now finally in sight, a speck at the end of long scree choked valley.

On arrival I realise it's not just one but a pair of lovingly maintained huts belonging to the Marlborough Tramping Club. They're sited on a commanding terrace and surprisingly, the smaller is named Tararua after the support of the Wellington based club to build it back in 1970.

It's only 1 pm, so after lunch we scout the route for the following day, study the hut log book for clues, snooze and much later enjoy a spectator sport watching the Nelson Tramping Club stagger, one by one, up the valley.

5 am and we're away under a clear and starry sky. One last crossing of the Hodder and we begin to follow Staircase Stream. In the dark, we blunder into the first waterfall (so much for yesterday's reccie). No matter, we find a greasy gut to shimmy up and we're back onto the sparsely cairned route that scrambles up scree and sharp rocks into the basin below the saddle connecting Tappie to Mt Alarm. At 2100m we reach the snow and at this hour of the morning it's crisp enough to immediately step into crampons.

Several hundred meters up we begin a long traverse below the pinnacle of 2711 as directed in the guide. It's steep and icy. Almost immediately I suffer an equipment malfunction (read human error

cockup), the toe of my crampon has come out of the boot. "Oh no! don't panic, dig a platform, resize and reattach..." But before I can take a swing of the adze, the crampon cunningly escapes the boot entirely and begins a jaunty freewheeling escape down the slope. I look on incredulously as the little devil slides merrily away. "Surely it will grip?" But no, on and on it careens, finally coming to a halt just short of where we began.

It's cold comfort to know crampon malfunction is how many of the famous climbing accidents begin. Still, it could be worse, at least it hasn't gone over a bluff. There's no choice but to down climb 150m on a solitary crampon and start over. By the time I get back to the little devil, dig a platform, resize and reattach, I could write the manual.

Meanwhile David has supposedly been perched on a rock keeping a concerned eye on my progress. When I finally catch up to him, at the base of the summit ridge, he's done his emails and is engrossed in the Sunday Herald online. Me? I'm shattered. The extra climb has been physically exhausting and I'm mentally drained from the narrow escape from what could easily been a much worse predicament.

There's no time to lose though, down below those Nelson trampers are at the base of the snow and there's no way we're going to be overtaken on the way to the summit. David leads out on what is the perfect alpine ridge for my skill level. Steep with spectacular drop-offs to keep us honest but nothing technical. After 40 minutes of oxygen depriving toil we run out of mountain. It's 10 am.

What a view! To the East, South and West lie the endless folds of multiple mountain ranges. To the north, across the shimmering ocean, lost in the haze, is Wellington. But the poignancy of finally getting to look across at my home from a mountain I've admired all my life is lost. I'm too busy cursing the patchy internet connection as I try to phone home and inflict text photos on unsuspecting friends (the Everest satellite phone heresy).



It's a thankfully uneventful descent back to the huts completed in 3 hours. After a long lunch we estimate there's just enough daylight left to walk back out before dark. Somehow going

downstream doesn't make it any easier and the diabolical snaking nature of the Hodder simply prolongs the agony as every corner feels like it should be the last. Just as darkness falls, one last lazy curve of the river reveals the silhouette of the bridge. It's been a 16 hour day but what an epic weekend - I'm hooked!

Thanks to all the Wellington Section instructors who selflessly gave up their weekends over the winter - I couldn't have done it without you.

Notices

National Climbing Camp 4-10 January 2016 at Tukino



[The Climbing camp](#) is being jointly hosted by the North Island sections with support from the Tukino Alpine Sports Club (TASC).

The camp is an opportunity for climbers to get together to climb mountains, rocks, socialise, explore and enjoy the great outdoors. Some people will choose to use the camp as a base for day walks while others will venture into the surrounding mountains or further afield (e.g. Whanganui Bay, Tongariro Crossing) for multi-day adventures.

Non climbing family members are welcome as well as members of overseas alpine clubs.

Enquiries can be directed to camp@alpineclub.org.nz

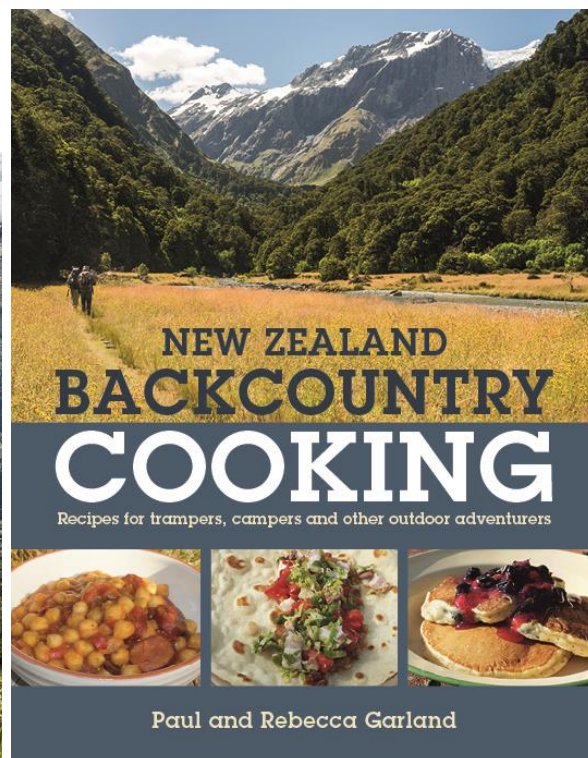
Trek with the Himalayan Trust in 2016



The HIMALAYAN TRUST NEPAL REBUILD CHALLENGE 2016 is a 17-day trek through the stunning Everest region – from Lukla up to Ama Dablam base camp – in support of the Himalayan Trust's Earthquake Rebuild Appeal. This is a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity to visit the schools and hospitals built by Sir Edmund Hillary and the Himalayan Trust and to help the Trust with the rebuild of a local high school – one year after the first devastating earthquake hit Nepal. Other highlights of the trip include a day exploring Namche Bazaar, a visit to Thyangboche monastery and breathtaking views of Mt Everest and the surrounding peaks. Throughout the trek you will experience the legendary warmth of the Sherpa people, which drew Sir Ed back to this region time after time.

Spaces are limited, so book now: <http://himalayantrust.org/trek/>

Book Discounts for Christmas



Until 31 December 2015 a 20% discount and free freight on Great Walks of New Zealand by Craig Potton and New Zealand Backcountry Cooking by Paul and Rebecca Garland is available to NZAC members. See the NZAC member benefits page for how to obtain your discount.

<https://alpineclub.org.nz/benefits-of-membership>

Query from the Mountain Club of South Africa

The Mountain Club of South Africa received an enquiry from a local lady who some years ago bought at auction in Cape Town a plaque, 8 cm. in diameter, with no provenance.



The style of dress of the climbers suggests an English or New Zealand, rather than South African, origin, perhaps of the 1960s or before. And the rucksack is a Bergan or Karrimor of that era.

If anyone can identify the date and story behind the plaque please contact Stephen Craven sacraven@mweb.co.za.

NZAC 2106 Alpine Calendar

Looking for the ultimate alternative to naff Christmas cards? Why not get your overseas friends and rellies one of the NZAC's 2016 calendars instead! Our calendars showcase the best from our very-own Photo Comp and so make a unique gift.

<https://alpineclub.org.nz/product/nzac-alpine-calendar-2016>



Wellington Section 2015 contacts list

We are always thankful for volunteers and members stepping forward to help the section run smoothly. If you'd like to learn more about how you could get involved, please email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz

Position	Name	Contact
Chairperson	Simon Williamson	021 054 7684
Co Chair	Eric Duggan	021 350 161
Treasurer	Mark Leslie	027 338 4458
Secretary / Vertigo Editor	Carolyn Ellis	021 574 287
Patron	John Nankervis	
Other Committee Members	Mark Johnston	027 924 4178
	Aviette Musin	021 0299 5390
Rock Drill Overseer	Kristen Foley	
Any membership, Distaghil Sar Fund, or general queries should be directed to the secretary		
Any media queries should be directed to:		
03 3777 595	National Executive Officer, Sam Newton	sam@alpineclub.org.nz



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* to be precise, this is just an average but we do aim for new routes every single week.



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